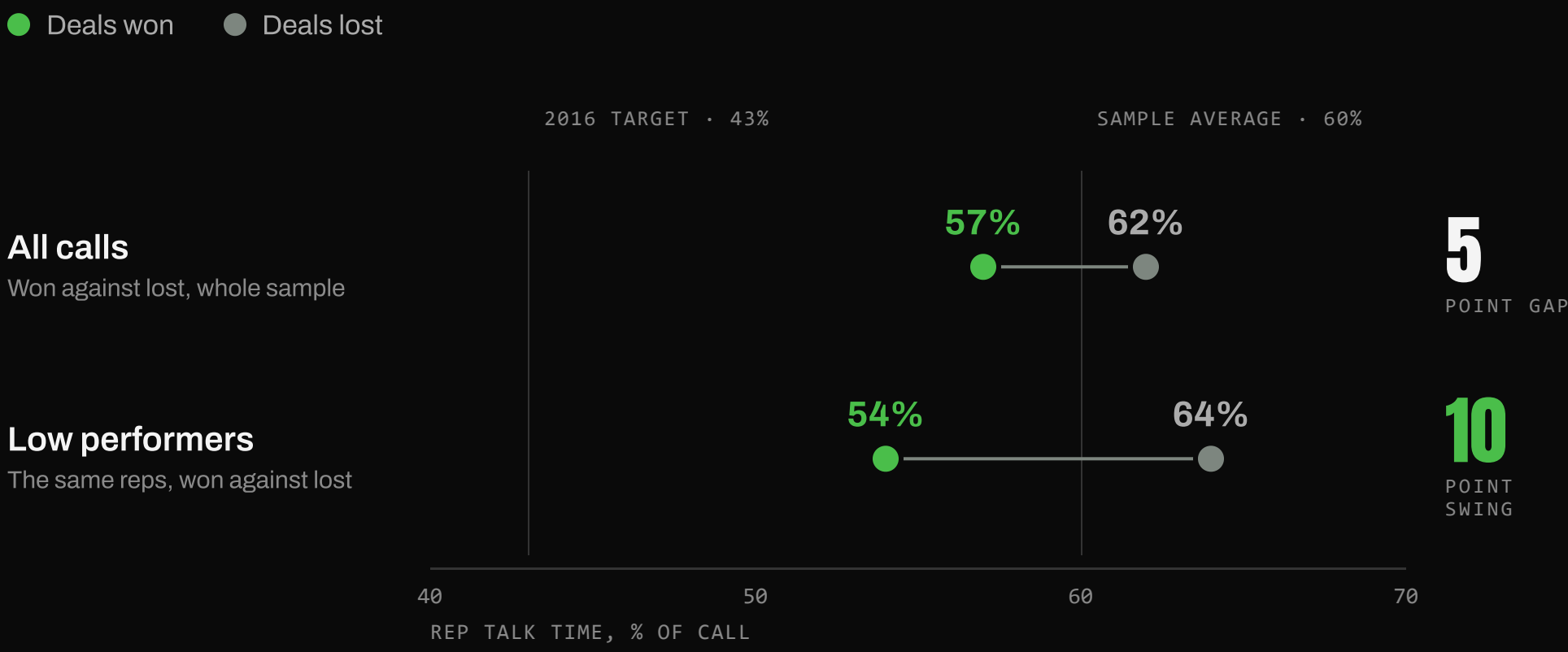
TALK-TO-LISTEN · 326,000 RECORDED CALLS

WATCH THE SWING. NOT THE TARGET.

The talk-time number that circulates in sales coaching is a 2016 figure. Set it against what a third of a million calls actually show and it is not just stale — it is measuring the wrong thing.



> High performers are reported to hold roughly the same ratio whether they win or lose. No figure is published for them, so no third row is drawn here.

OUR READ

The gap between a won call and a lost one is five points. The old rule asked reps to cut seventeen. Meanwhile the same reps move ten points between their own good days and bad ones — and a rep whose talk time climbs on a call going badly is not talking more on purpose. They have lost the thread and are filling the silence. A target number hides that. The swing is what shows it.

Source: Gong, “Mastering the talk-to-listen ratio in sales calls” — 326,000 sales calls of at least ten minutes. Originally authored 2016 by Chris Orlob, current version by Dan Morgese; last modified 4 March 2026. Read first-hand 14 September 2026.
“5” and “10” are our subtraction on the published figures, not claims made by the source.

SURGE